

Speaker 1 [00:00:04]: So, how would you like us to name your partner? Spouse, girlfriend? Is there a name you're more comfortable with?

Speaker 2 [00:00:13]: We can call them [partner].

Speaker 1 [00:00:16]: Very well, by their name. How long have you been with [partner]?

Speaker 2 [00:00:20]: We've been together for [1-5] years.

Speaker 1 [00:00:23]: Ok, very good. First, I would like you to simply tell me about the love story you are currently living with your partner.

Speaker 2 [00:00:32]: The broad strokes?

Speaker 1 [00:00:33]: In general terms.

Speaker 2 [00:00:36]: So, we met [1-5] years ago on a dating app. We quickly started dating. It's been [1-5] years now that we live together, and I would say things are going rather well. We get along well, it's harmonious, we argue like all couples, but I think that's normal. But overall, I think we're happy together. At least, I'm happy with him.

Speaker 1 [00:01:04]: So, you said you met on a dating app?

Speaker 2 [00:01:08]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:01:09]: Can you tell me a bit more about it? How did that meeting go?

Speaker 2 [00:01:13]: Yes, which app and all?

Speaker 1 [00:01:16]: Yes, just the general context of the meeting.

Speaker 2 [00:01:22]: So, we met on the app, we chatted for a few days. We met up fairly quickly because with dating apps, otherwise, you never finish exchanging messages and you don't know where you stand anymore. So I wanted to meet him quite quickly because I didn't have much time left in [city] at that time. We met in [City]; I was there for [1-5] year. And it's true that I wasn't specifically looking for a serious relationship, I admit, but I needed someone in my life. When we matched, I had [1-5] months left on my contract in [City], so my contract was coming to an end. I'd already had a few bad dates, so I thought, "Well, I've got nothing to lose." So we met up after [1-5] week, and it went really well. We spent [1-5] hours together, talked very freely, we were very comfortable, and that's it. So we saw each other again very quickly. I admit, I'm not very proactive, so it's largely thanks to him that things moved quickly afterwards. I'm the type to think, "Okay, we had one date, it's not a big deal if we don't see each other for [6-10] days." But not him. [1-5] days later, he was at my door saying, "I'm taking you here, we're doing this, we're doing that." And he quickly showed me he was there for me and wanted to be there for me, and despite myself, it turned into a serious relationship even though I wasn't looking for one at all.

Speaker 1 [00:02:54]: I see. So if I understand correctly, you weren't originally from [City]?

Speaker 2 [00:03:01]: No, I'm from [City].

Speaker 1 [00:03:04]: So you're [Nationality]?

Speaker 2 [00:03:04]: I'm [Nationality].

Speaker 1 [00:03:05]: And you went to [City] for?

Speaker 2 [00:03:08]: I went to [City] for a year for a [occupation]. It was a [1-5]-year contract with a [association] that sends volunteers around the world. I was in charge of partnerships in [Continent]. So I wasn't looking for a serious relationship because I had this [1-5]-year contract that led to [1-5] months of travel in [Continent]. Plus, I was in the process of getting my visa for [Country]. I hadn't planned to stay. But I had just come out of a complicated long-term relationship and needed someone else to forget the previous person.

Speaker 1 [00:03:48]: Okay.

Speaker 2 [00:03:49]: So I really needed someone. I felt lonely, so even though I only had [1-5] months left, I was still on the apps, not giving up on finding someone to share something with. But I didn't want it to be serious because of [Continent] and [Country]. I didn't want to impose that on someone or fall in love at that moment.

Speaker 1 [00:04:07]: If I understand correctly, it was because - sorry I interrupted you, you were going to say something?

Speaker 2 [00:04:10]: No, not at all.

Speaker 1 [00:04:12]: So if I understand correctly, you weren't looking for something serious because you knew you were going to have to leave afterwards.

Speaker 2 [00:04:16]: Yes, I knew I was going to have to leave. And I was still in love with my ex-boyfriend. Honestly, [partner] deserves credit because, at our first meeting, I told him transparently, "I'm looking to forget my ex. I just came out of a difficult breakup, I'm still a bit in love with him. Plus, I'm planning to spend [1-5] months in [Continent] and I'm getting ready to go to [Country]." So I told him I wasn't looking for anything serious and laid everything on the table. He knew. Yet, he managed to make us end up together [1-5] and a half months later, and I fell in love quite quickly.

Speaker 1 [00:04:53]: He managed well.

Speaker 2 [00:04:54]: Yes, he managed very well.

Speaker 1 [00:04:57]: Can you tell me a bit more about the development of the relationship? You've described the beginning and the meeting. Because you've been together for [1-5] years, right?

Speaker 2 [00:05:06]: Yes, we've been together for [1-5] years. So, the rest of the story.

Speaker 1 [00:05:12]: Yes, roughly what comes to mind.

Speaker 2 [00:05:15]: So what happened, what triggered a lot of things for me was that we had been seeing each other for barely [1-5] weeks, we weren't yet officially together, and my goddaughter was supposed to visit me in [City]. That weekend, I got a terrible flu. I fainted three times, had a fever, and wasn't well. My goddaughter, who was [11-15] at the time, wanted to explore [City] on her own, and I felt guilty letting her go alone, but I couldn't show her around. On the other hand, she was there for [1-5] days and wanted to make the most of it, which I understood. [Partner] was sweet and offered to pick her up by motorcycle, bring her to me, be there if she had any issues, take her on visits, and even went to the pharmacy to get me medicine. In the evening, we went to the cinema together, and my goddaughter said she found him great. That weekend, he showed me he was very invested despite me saying I wanted nothing serious. He was there for me, taking care of my goddaughter and showing he cared.

Speaker 1 [00:07:07]: Uh-huh.

Speaker 2 [00:07:07]: At that time, I was living with intrusive roommates, and he was living with his father. So, I met his father after [1-5] weeks, and when my mother came to help me move [1-5] and a half months later, I introduced her to him. It went well with his father and my mother. The serious relationship came naturally. When all signals are green, even if you don't want something serious, you get carried away. I don't regret it. He later applied for a [Country] visa. We couldn't go because of COVID, but he joined my project.

Speaker 1 [00:07:07]: Hmm.

Speaker 2 [00:07:07]: During the COVID lockdown, I stayed in [Country] after my contract ended. I didn't want to be locked down with his father, so I went home. We didn't see each other for [1-5] months. As soon as the lockdown was lifted, he rode his motorcycle from [City] to [City] to see me. He's always been very invested in our relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:07:35]: So, if I understand correctly, what was important for you was feeling like you could rely on him quite quickly.

Speaker 2 [00:07:40]: Yes, absolutely, I think that's it. And even today, I tell him that his primary quality, which he hates when I say, is that he's a practical guy. He always has a solution for everything, whether it's apartment-related or personal. He always wants to help, and when he can, he does. Sometimes, I just want to confide without seeking a solution, but he still tries to help. He doesn't understand when I complain without wanting a solution. Maybe it's a female thing, I don't know (laughs). But he always seeks solutions, which is comfortable because you know you can count on him.

Speaker 1 [00:08:48]: Very well. If you were to compare the quality of your current relationship with those of your friends, what would you say? Compared to your friends' relationships with their partners.

Speaker 2 [00:09:02]: I think the couples we know and hang out with are quite close. Maybe the thing we have over some couples we know is that we have no taboos; we can talk about everything, even if it leads to clashes. We say everything we think, sometimes things we maybe shouldn't. Sometimes we fight, but we're not afraid of fighting and can discuss anything. That's great. For instance, I have a friend whose boyfriend is very authoritative with her. He criticizes her way of walking, her phone mannerisms. It drives me crazy. I tell her to stand up to him, but she says she can't because he'll get offended. I tell her if [partner] did something like that, I'd react immediately, and I think he'd do the same. But we never have that issue because we communicate openly and honestly.

Speaker 1 [00:10:21]: You said maybe we shouldn't say everything.

Speaker 2 [00:10:25]: Yes (laughs).

Speaker 1 [00:10:25]: Jokingly.

Speaker 2 [00:10:26]: Yes, sometimes I get angry and say harsh things. It rarely happens, but I realize sometimes I'm harsh. I think he deserves it at that moment. But overall, we say what needs to be said. I'm impulsive, and I know sometimes I can be a bit harsh.

Speaker 1 [00:10:57]: You said what sometimes bothers you is when a friend's partner is too authoritative.

Speaker 2 [00:11:08]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:11:09]: So maybe what you like in your relationship is its equality. Is that something...

Speaker 2 [00:11:14]: Yes, but that's also a reason for our disputes. Sometimes he's a bit bossy. He was a [leader] in [Country], which is very different from in [Country]. Everyone I know in [Country] was a [leader]. Because he was a [leader], he's sometimes bossy with me, which I can't stand because I can be like that too. When we clash, it's often because of that. We both dislike being told what to do, but we can't help it. But he would never criticize my mannerisms or voice on the phone. That's not his style.

Speaker 1 [00:12:15]: You find that unhealthy.

Speaker 2 [00:12:17]: Yes, I do. I've told my friend it's unhealthy for her boyfriend to comment on her walk. He has nothing to say about her behavior. We should accept our partners as they are, including their flaws. Sure, some things might annoy us, but we should communicate without trying to change each other.

Speaker 1 [00:13:09]: So you think it's about acceptance.

Speaker 2 [00:13:13]: Yes, I think so. In a couple, you have to accept each other's flaws and qualities. There are things about [partner] that annoy me, and I'm sure there are things about

me that annoy him too. But we talk about it without trying to force changes. His mannerisms shouldn't be a problem. We need to accept our partners as they are.

Speaker 1 [00:13:48]: You've compared your current relationship to those of your friends. If you were to compare it to your previous relationships, what would you say?

Speaker 2 [00:14:02]: It's healthier.

Speaker 1 [00:14:04]: Healthier?

Speaker 2 [00:14:05]: Yes, my previous relationship before [partner] was complicated and strange. But the one before that, which lasted [1-5] years, I knew I wasn't truly in love but stayed out of comfort because we got along well. He was practical and reliable, but I realized I didn't love him anymore. With [partner], I have all those qualities, but I also love him. I'm not with him just for comfort or because I feel stuck. We have no taboos, and that's new for me. I'm never afraid to be myself or spontaneous with him. With my exes, there were times I felt uncomfortable. For example, with one ex, I wore foundation to bed for the first [1-5] months because I couldn't stand the thought of him seeing me without makeup. With [partner], I don't care. I can be myself, and we love each other without worrying about appearances or behavior. It's natural and spontaneous, and that's wonderful. The major difference is that this relationship is balanced, transparent, and pleasant.

Speaker 1 [00:15:56]: It seems like acceptance is a recurring theme for you, which you might have had less of in previous relationships, like with makeup or behavior.

Speaker 2 [00:16:10]: Maybe, but I think age plays a role too. I'm not old, I'm [26-30] but at [21-25], you don't have the same self-image or confidence. Now, I don't wear foundation day or night, which would never occur to me. But I think it's also about self-perception. I've gained confidence because I have a stable personal and professional life. Now, I accept things and don't feel the need to control myself or my image, especially in my relationship. Everything happens naturally. I don't know how else to explain it.

Speaker 1 [00:16:51]: Naturally.

Speaker 2 [00:16:54]: Yes, it's natural. Everything is natural.

Speaker 1 [00:16:57]: Could we say it's a relationship where you feel safe?

Speaker 2 [00:17:01]: Yes, completely.

Speaker 1 [00:17:03]: Yes, you mentioned you could open up to your partner and be yourself. In situations of need or distress, or when you feel in danger, does that contribute to the quality of the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:17:24]: I didn't understand the question, sorry.

Speaker 1 [00:17:26]: It's more of a discussion than specific questions.

Speaker 2 [00:17:30]: I'm not sure what to say.

Speaker 1 [00:17:31]: Just say what comes to mind. You mentioned opening up to him and being yourself without fear of judgment or consequences. I wanted to know if you also receive comfort and attention from your partner, from [partner], when you're in distress or danger.

Speaker 2 [00:17:58]: Yes, he's not especially protective, but I know I can count on him to protect me if needed. I'm not the type to need a protective man hovering over me. I manage on my own, but I know I can rely on him in tough situations. What I said earlier, I know he's there, which is reassuring. I believe I can handle any situation with him by my side.

Speaker 1 [00:18:30]: Do you have examples of situations where you could rely on him, where you could open up or...?

Speaker 2 [00:18:41]: Not specifically. Not specifically, but for example, when we moved into this apartment, everything had to be redone. [Partner] bought it, so I rent from him, we live together in his place. Everything needed fixing, and I was panicking, thinking, "We're supposed to move in [Month], it's [Month], and we need to redo everything." I was totally stressed, but he said, "Don't worry, it'll be fine." And I thought, "Yes, it's [partner], if he says it'll be ready, it will be." And it was. We redid the plumbing, electricity, floors, walls—everything. I would have been 1000 times more stressed with someone else. But because it was [partner] handling it, and he said it would be ready by [Month], I wasn't stressed. I trusted him. With someone else, I might have shared the stress or they might have projected their stress onto me. But [partner] said, "It'll be ready," and I didn't worry because I trusted him. I knew he would get it done.

Speaker 1 [00:19:59]: You said, "I trust him," which seems to be a recurring theme in how you talk about him.

Speaker 2 [00:20:03]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:20:05]: Is it...

Speaker 2 [00:20:07]: Yes, I trust him. I think it's important. It's the foundation.

Speaker 1 [00:20:13]: It's the foundation, you say.

Speaker 2 [00:20:14]: Yes. Yes, kindness and trust are the most important things.

Speaker 1 [00:20:21]: I'd like you to tell me about what, for you, constitutes a high-quality relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:20:27]: A high-quality relationship?

Speaker 1 [00:20:30]: Yes.

Speaker 2 [00:20:31]: I realized this with my relationship with [partner], compared to my previous one. My ex was tall and muscular, physically imposing, with a personality to match. We were together for [6-10] months, and during that time, I felt small. I was used to being the one with the stronger character, more outgoing, wanting to go out. But with him, he was the life of the party, with the strongest personality. I couldn't find my place, and I think that's why it failed. I loved him a lot, but I didn't like who I was with him because I felt small. Now I know a successful relationship is when you love the person and love who you are with them. When you feel comfortable in your skin, with someone who makes you feel good as you are, without needing to play a role to please them. That was my issue with my previous relationship. I was too in love with him, trying too hard to please him. We started as friends, got along great, and discovered we were in love with each other. But when we started dating, I think he lost what he loved about me because I started to diminish myself, feeling overshadowed by his personality. I wasn't myself anymore, and that's what ruined it. Luckily, now I'm in a more fulfilling relationship. So, yes, for me, loving someone and loving who you are with them is very important. Feeling good in the relationship without playing a role or desperately trying to please the other person. Now, I realize it didn't work because I wasn't happy in that relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:23:39]: How do you know you're in a relationship where you're yourself? How can you tell?

Speaker 2 [00:23:44]: That's a good question. How do you know if you're yourself? I don't know. I don't know how to answer that, sorry.

Speaker 1 [00:23:56]: No problem.

Speaker 2 [00:23:57]: It's a matter of feeling, I think. When you don't have to make an effort, when everything is natural. When you don't feel the need to control what you say or do, when you don't rethink the day wondering what you did wrong. I was in a vicious cycle of thinking, "Why isn't he falling in love with me? What did I do wrong? Maybe I should be more like this or that." With [partner], I don't question myself. I'm just myself, and it goes well.

Speaker 1 [00:24:31]: When would you say you've been the least yourself in your current relationship with [partner]?

Speaker 2 [00:24:47]: I don't think there has been a specific moment when I didn't feel like myself. No.

Speaker 1 [00:24:55]: Conversely, is there a moment when you felt even more yourself?

Speaker 2 [00:25:02]: No, I think it's constant. There aren't many highs or lows.

Speaker 1 [00:25:12]: You also mentioned fulfillment in the relationship. Similarly, how can you tell you're in a fulfilling relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:25:25]: Again, it's a matter of feeling. You know when you're happy and when you're not. For me, it took hindsight to realize I wasn't happy before. But now, because I've

experienced unfulfilling relationships, I can more easily recognize when things are going well. I'm in a fulfilling relationship because I don't question or stress about it. I know it's fulfilling because I've had relationships that weren't.

Speaker 1 [00:25:53]: Was there a moment in this relationship when you felt less fulfilled than at other times?

Speaker 2 [00:25:59]: No, not really. There isn't a notable moment where I thought, "What am I doing with him?" No.

Speaker 1 [00:26:09]: Okay. You've talked about what constitutes a high-quality relationship for you. I'd like you to tell me what a low-quality relationship is for you, the opposite.

Speaker 2 [00:26:20]: A low-quality relationship is one where you constantly question yourself, trying to understand what you're doing wrong, what could please the other person, what you should change to make it work. If you have to make significant efforts to change your personality to please the other person, it's not compatible. In a low-quality relationship, you don't feel like yourself, you lack trust, and you can't talk openly about everything. Additionally, when you have flaws, like being jealous or needing reassurance, the other person's qualities should complement your flaws. A bad relationship is when the other person amplifies your flaws, making you feel worse about yourself. In a good relationship, both people lift each other up, balancing each other's flaws and qualities.

Speaker 1 [00:28:05]: You mentioned compatibility.

Speaker 2 [00:28:12]: Yes, compatibility is essential. It's about matching qualities, flaws, and personalities. You need someone whose personality fits with yours without overshadowing it.

Speaker 1 [00:28:32]: You also mentioned making efforts; for you, it's not necessarily a good thing.

Speaker 2 [00:28:37]: Making efforts for the other person is fine, but not to change yourself to please them. If you need to change to fit into the relationship, something is wrong. It's about accepting each other and the relationship working naturally.

Speaker 1 [00:29:22]: You've talked about what you consider important in a high-quality or low-quality relationship. Are there other things that are important to you in a romantic relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:29:22]: Trust, being able to rely on each other, having no taboos, communicating freely. Having common interests is also important. For example, I had a very sporty dad who pushed me to do sports, and it's something I value. On dating apps, if someone didn't do sports, it was a deal-breaker. [Partner] is very sporty, even more than me, and we share that. It's important to have common interests and the mindset that comes with them. I couldn't be with someone who lacks ambition or doesn't take care of themselves. [Partner] and I went on a holiday to [Location], and we were both eager to wake up at 4:30 am to hike and see the sunrise. Not everyone would do that. Sharing common interests is important.

Speaker 1 [00:31:00]: It comes back to compatibility.

Speaker 2 [00:31:03]: Yes, always.

Speaker 1 [00:31:04]: You mentioned communication and trust are important to you.

Speaker 2 [00:31:15]: Yes, communication goes hand in hand with being able to say everything. Trusting each other is crucial, knowing you can say things without fear of judgment.

Speaker 1 [00:31:38]: And again, being yourself.

Speaker 2 [00:31:41]: Yes, spontaneity in a couple is essential. Being able to be yourself without fear of judgment or repercussions.

Speaker 1 [00:31:49]: Spontaneity, you said.

Speaker 2 [00:31:51]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:31:52]: Something unreflective?

Speaker 2 [00:31:55]: Yes, in a way. Not having to think before speaking, even if it's sometimes better to do so. But not fearing saying something that might... I can't stand walking on eggshells in a relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:32:15]: You briefly mentioned it earlier, but I'd like you to talk more about what love is for you, based on your experience.

Speaker 2 [00:32:24]: Well, for me, love is accepting someone completely, with their qualities and flaws, without trying to change them. Loving the person and loving who you are with them.

Speaker 1 [00:32:51]: Pardon, go on.

Speaker 2 [00:32:52]: Sorry, I was going to say it's important for a balanced relationship where both feel good.

Speaker 1 [00:33:01]: How important is it for you in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:33:06]: What?

Speaker 1 [00:33:06]: Love.

Speaker 2 [00:33:06]: The fact that we feel? I didn't understand.

Speaker 1 [00:33:12]: How important would you say love is for you in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:33:15]: Oh, love?

Speaker 1 [00:33:15]: Yes.

Speaker 2 [00:33:16]: It's essential.

Speaker 1 [00:33:18]: Essential?

Speaker 1 [00:33:19]: Today, yes. Before, I had shorter relationships where I wasn't particularly in love. I was still figuring myself out and didn't really know what love was. I think it's only through various relationships, both short and long, that we can define what makes us happy and what love truly is. This process refines our criteria and helps us understand what love means to us. Now, I'm sure I'm in a 100% healthy and loving relationship, and it's very important to me. It wasn't as important before because I spent three years with someone I didn't love. I realize that now. I didn't realize it at the time. I thought I was in love. Now, at [26-30], with my past experiences, I understand what love really is. I wouldn't want to be in a relationship where I don't feel love anymore.

Speaker 1 [00:34:12]: So what makes you say, "I realize now"? What's the difference that made you think you were in love but weren't, and now you understand why you thought you were in love when you weren't?

Speaker 2 [00:34:26]: Well, because I was staying with that person for comfort. But I didn't realize it. I think I was fooling myself. I realized it because I left for [6-10] months and developed feelings for someone else. I thought, "Why stay with him when I could be with this other person?" But then I thought, "I can't leave him because he's always there for me, he knows about real estate, he advises me." It's horrible, but he was a good match. He was always there for me, had a stable financial and emotional situation, and he loved me. He told me all the time. I thought, "I can't leave him. I'd be a monster to leave someone with all these qualities." But then I realized, "Despite all his qualities, I'm not in love." It's not fair to stay with someone just because the relationship is comfortable and he's a good match and kind. He deserves better than that. I ended up breaking up because I realized it wasn't honest towards him.

Speaker 1 [00:35:35]: So it was falling in love afterward that made you realize?

Speaker 2 [00:35:40]: It helped me realize, but I think it was the geographic distance that gave me perspective.

Speaker 1 [00:35:50]: Ah, I see.

Speaker 2 [00:35:51]: I had been in [Country] for [1-5] and a half months at that time. I went to [Country] before applying for my visa. I initially went for [1-5] and a half months and ended up staying [6-10] months. He decided to visit me there. I thought I'd be thrilled to see him, but I saw it as an intrusion into the life I built there. I didn't want him there. That's when I realized, "Wow, I'm not in love." It was the distance and living a great experience far away that made me see his arrival as an intrusion. When he left, I realized I wasn't in love and that I was interested in someone else.

Speaker 1 [00:36:43]: Hmm.

Speaker 2 [00:36:43]: It's horrible, but I broke up with him after he came all the way to [Country] for me. It was the distance and the chance to reflect that made me realize it wasn't love keeping me with him, just everything he did for me daily. Meeting someone else helped too. I think I have an issue with loneliness. (laughs) I struggle not having a man in my life, whether it's a serious relationship or not. I need someone to say "goodnight" to at night and "good morning" to in the morning, someone to rely on.

Speaker 1 [00:37:30]: You said, "I think I have an issue with loneliness."

Speaker 2 [00:37:34]: Because I realize that since I started dating, which was late, I was [16-20] with my first boyfriend, I've never been alone for more than [1-5] consecutive months. Completely alone, no. There's always been someone, whether a close friend or a serious relationship. When I wasn't, I felt bad and lonely. That's why I joined dating apps at some point. So, yeah, I'm not good at being alone. (laughs)

Speaker 1 [00:38:22]: There are different forms and ways of loving, and I'd like you to talk about how you know your partner loves you.

Speaker 2 [00:38:29]: Hmm. How do I know he loves me? Hmm, that's a good question. How do I know he loves me? He's there for me even when I'm difficult, which is significant. I can always count on him. Sometimes, I don't have specific problems he needs to solve, but I know that even if we argue, he'd still be there for me. I can't imagine him dismissing me if I had an issue, saying, "Deal with it yourself" or "You've annoyed me, you deserve it." I know we can always rely on each other. I don't know if this is related to trust, but I think it is. It's this mutual trust. But how to be sure he loves me? The fact that he's spontaneous with me too, I can feel it. Yes. I don't know.

Speaker 1 [00:39:38]: Take your time to think.

Speaker 2 [00:39:39]: It's a matter of feeling and intuition. I can feel he loves me. We say it a lot to each other. You can say it without meaning it, but no, I feel that he's also comfortable with me, spontaneous, and natural with me. I think these are signs of trust, just as I trust him. As long as I don't sense he's defensive or hiding things, I believe he loves me and is happy with me. I think.

Speaker 1 [00:40:19]: You mentioned spontaneity.

Speaker 2 [00:40:21]: Again, yeah.

Speaker 1 [00:40:22]: Yes, again, why not. I'd like you to tell me about one of the latest positive interactions you had with [partner].

Speaker 2 [00:40:35]: One of the latest positive interactions, well, we have a lot of positive interactions. What do you define as a positive interaction?

Speaker 1 [00:40:41]: What you define as a positive interaction.

Speaker 2 [00:40:44]: Oh, I don't know what a positive interaction is.

Speaker 1 [00:40:48]: For you.

Speaker 2 [00:40:51]: Well, for example, earlier, I told him I had a contract with a client that ended, and I didn't feel like I did a good job and was upset it didn't go well. It ended well, but it ended, and it bothered me. He said, "It's not your fault. You did what you had to do. They shouldn't have hired you in the first place." I thought, "Oh, yeah, that's true." Just the fact that he listened to me and said, "It's not your fault" made me feel better. We have positive interactions every day, thankfully, but I don't really know what a positive interaction is.

Speaker 1 [00:41:38]: You've given one, something that you consider a positive interaction. There isn't necessarily a universal definition. Conversely, you were about to say something.

Speaker 2 [00:41:49]: No, no, no, no, no. Conversely, a negative interaction?

Speaker 1 [00:41:53]: Absolutely. I'd like you to tell me about one of the latest negative interactions you've had.

Speaker 2 [00:41:58]: Hmm. Well, we often argue about the same things. Either it's about the general upkeep of the apartment. I know I'm a bit too meticulous at times, and I'm aware of it, but I'm independent, I work from home, and I'm there all day. He leaves for work all day. Sometimes [redacted].. We argue a lot about that. Also, sometimes I find him clumsy because he's too pragmatic and not emotional enough. For instance, my dad is sick, and once, it ended in tears and anger because he questioned the doctor's diagnosis. I told him, "You know I'm already very worried, and instead of reassuring me, you're making me doubt the doctor." That's not what I needed to hear. It was insensitive. My dad is seeing specialists, and the diagnosis is accurate. We argued because he sometimes lacks empathy. He can be empathetic but clumsy in his reactions. He struggles to anticipate how I might react and find the right words for things that matter to me. For example, now I don't even want to tell him what my dad says because I know he won't find the right words.

Speaker 1 [00:44:11]: Emotionally speaking, you find that sometimes...

Speaker 2 [00:44:14]: Yeah, we don't react the same way. He struggles to anticipate and understand that some things affect me. It's not a lack of empathy because he has empathy at work, but a lack of interest in what I might feel. His spontaneity can be problematic. He says what he thinks without filtering, not considering the impact on me. For example, questioning the doctor's decision about my dad when he knows it worries me. I don't need more doubts. I need reassurance. He says, "I'm not here to tell you what you need to hear. I'm worried too, and I can share my doubts." But it's not his father. We argued for 45 minutes, yelling. I realized he can't anticipate my emotional reactions. There have been other instances like this, but I can't recall specific examples. Sometimes he can't find the right words for serious matters.

Speaker 1 [00:45:27]: You said it might be due to a lack of interest in what you feel?

Speaker 2 [00:45:33]: Yes, or a lack of tact. Even regarding my work, when he comes home, I always ask about his day, but he rarely asks about mine. If I talk about it, he might pretend to be interested, but he seldom shows genuine interest. For example, I might mention an upcoming client meeting, but he won't follow up later. I admit it frustrates me. It's my main complaint. He has flaws. If he were perfect, I'd fear losing him. (laughs) But yes, my main complaint is his lack of interest in my feelings. He thinks if I want to talk, I'll bring it up. And it's true, but sometimes I wish it came from him.

Speaker 1 [00:46:30]: You said you'd like it to come from him, but also that he makes an effort to show interest sometimes. You mentioned spontaneity earlier. Would it still make you happy even if it wasn't entirely spontaneous, or is it just a character mismatch?

Speaker 2 [00:46:55]: It's something I've accepted. If I have something to tell him, I know he won't remember to ask later. I'll take the initiative to tell him and ask if he's interested in knowing. "Oh, yes, tell me." But I know he's like that, and I accept it. It's pointless trying to change people. I know his flaws and accept them. His qualities outweigh his flaws. It frustrates me, but he knows. I sometimes tease him, "You don't ask how it went," but that's just how he is. I won't force him to care about things that don't interest him. If he thinks it's my job to bring it up, I'll do that. I understand his point of view and respect it. So I take the initiative to share what I want to discuss. For serious emotional matters, I anticipate if he can respond well or if it'll stress him out. I also have friends I can rely on and talk to about everything. We talk about everything, but he's not always attentive to every topic, and I don't blame him. It's normal.

Speaker 1 [00:48:28]: You mentioned these disputes you have. How do you resolve them? How did this one get resolved?

Speaker 2 [00:48:36]: I'm terrible because I can go to bed angry. (laughs) He can't stand that. Knowing it bothers him, I fall asleep even faster. (laughs) It's not good, but we often argue in the evening after work, go to bed angry, and the next day act like nothing happened. We love each other and move on. Given our authoritative personalities, we struggle to agree and apologize. We have our pride. He's very proud. I'm stubborn and can hold grudges. He's very proud, so I know it's a lost cause. I think, "What's the point of staying angry the next day?" We'll argue about the same things in a few days. So we move on. We're still happy. It's an implicit strategy. We forget. The next day, we act like nothing happened. It works because our arguments aren't about critical issues that could harm our relationship. We know it's not worth revisiting because we won't understand each other, but it's not a big deal.

Speaker 1 [00:51:01]: You said we act like we forgot.

Speaker 2 [00:51:05]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:51:06]: Meaning you haven't forgotten.

Speaker 2 [00:51:09]: No, I accumulate things that annoy me about him, like his pride, his authoritarian nature, or lack of empathy and interest. These are significant complaints, but I

accept them because his qualities are worth it, and I'm happy in our relationship. So, yes, it annoys me, but it doesn't harm our relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:51:44]: So the idea is to let time pass.

Speaker 2 [00:51:48]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:51:49]: Let emotions settle and then...

Speaker 2 [00:51:54]: Yes, because I'm impulsive. When I react emotionally, it ends in tears. I rarely cry when I'm sad, but when I'm angry, I cry and get mad, and it leads to harsh words. So yes, I know I can be tough sometimes. But it's rare. We've had maybe three major arguments in four years. Generally, they're minor disputes, typical couple squabbles. Discussing with friends, we all have the same issues. With my ex, we never fought, and it didn't work because we couldn't express ourselves. I was too afraid of pushing him away, so I didn't say anything. With [partner], I'm not afraid to push him away, so I say everything. The next day, it's forgotten because we love each other.

Speaker 1 [00:53:06]: You said you could be harsh or even mean in these interactions.

Speaker 2 [00:53:12]: Yes, yes, harsh in the sense that I'll tell him he's too stupid to understand or things like that. I'll say, "There are things we'll never understand about each other. You're really bad at this." Yes, I've said that. Regarding my dad, I told him he was stupid, clueless, and had no empathy. I told him if he can't anticipate that this will upset me, he doesn't know me. I say everything because my emotions take over. I know it's harsh, but I mean it at the moment. I don't think he's bad in general, just in that instance. I tell him he was bad and should apologize. But he doesn't and doesn't understand why he was wrong. Even when we discuss it later, he insists I overreacted. We don't understand each other on some things, but it's okay. We don't have to agree on everything.

Speaker 1 [00:54:20]: Alright. You might have touched on this, but I'd like you to talk more generally about the challenges you've faced or are facing in your relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:54:38]: Honestly, the biggest challenge was me getting attached and falling in love. That was hard for me. For instance, I never felt committed long-term. Moving in with someone for years always scared me. With my ex, living with him for [1-5] months during my internship in [City] was anxiety-inducing. With [partner], I thought it would scare me, but I was excited to move in with him. I think the main challenge was personal. Now that we've been living together for [1-5] years, and it's going well, I feel at home. I don't feel the need for my independence or my place, as I did with my ex. Initially, I wanted my apartment in [City] while he had his. But with [partner], we moved in together, and two years later, everything's fine. That's my biggest challenge, but it's personal. For us, there aren't many challenges.

Speaker 1 [00:56:19]: You said falling in love was a challenge.

Speaker 2 [00:56:24]: Yes, but it was about commitment. I struggled with committing to a long-term relationship. I was selfish before [partner], focusing on myself. With my ex, I left for [1-5] months in [Country] without considering his opinion. I extended my stay without consulting him. My personal desires always came first. Now, my relationship is my life. It's essential. I used to be selfish, thinking only of myself. Now, I'm not.

Speaker 1 [00:57:30]: Why do you think this has changed? What changed in you?

Speaker 2 [00:57:34]: Now, I genuinely need to be with him and value his approval. We're truly a couple. Before, it was two individuals together. My projects were mine, my life was mine. Today, it's because I'm truly in love and have learned from past mistakes. My projects are also his. He's very open. When I mentioned moving to [Country], he immediately asked if he could join and applied for a visa. He's very committed, which doesn't scare me. Now, I wouldn't make decisions without his approval because it matters a lot to me.

Speaker 1 [00:58:42]: Do you think it's because this is the first time you're really in love, or were the others just confusing emotions?

Speaker 2 [00:58:50]: It's the first time I'm truly in love and feel like a long-term couple. I always sensed something was off in previous relationships, whether it was a lack of love or feeling out of place. Now, everything feels right. It's about feeling. I'm just happy and can't see myself without him. So I think I'm truly in love.

Speaker 1 [00:59:23]: You mentioned conflicts earlier. Over two weeks, how often do these disputes or conflicts arise?

Speaker 2 [00:59:32]: Disputes? I don't know. Over two weeks? It's hard to say because some weeks we don't argue at all, and other weeks we argue three times. On average, maybe once every two weeks. But it's been a while since we went to bed angry. We don't argue often, maybe once every two weeks, but not to the point of going to bed angry.

Speaker 1 [01:00:26]: You said you had your first partner at [16-20] and haven't been alone since. How many partners have you had approximately?

Speaker 2 [01:00:37]: Oh, I don't know. Hmm. I was in a relationship for [1-5] and a half years in college, then left him for [Name], with whom I stayed for [1-5] years but wasn't really in love. So that's [1-5]. Then I left [Name] for a [Nationality], with whom I stayed for [1-5] month. After that, I had a brief relationship with someone else for [1-5] months, but he was a jerk. Then I dated my ex before [partner] for [6-10] months. We remained friends, but it was unhealthy because he controlled me, and I was still in love with him. During this period, I met [partner], trying to break free from my ex's control. So I don't know how many. There were some failed attempts too.

Speaker 1 [01:02:08]: What do you consider relationships?

Speaker 2 [01:02:11]: Yes, I'd say around [6-10].

Speaker 1 [01:02:18]: Okay, great. Besides how you resolve conflicts, what other ways do you maintain your relationship?

Speaker 2 [01:02:38]: Running together, working out together, planning vacations and trips together. Our friends too. He has great friends, and I get along well with them. He gets along with mine too. It's nice that I've been accepted into his social circle in [Country]. We share friends and a social life, which is important for both of us. Maintaining friendships and not just spending time with each other is crucial. We make plans, run together, discuss, and keep things exciting, avoiding routine.

Speaker 1 [01:04:15]: What do you mean by routine?

Speaker 2 [01:04:17]: Routine is doing the same thing every day, not planning trips or exciting activities. For example, we have a road trip planned with friends in [Month], and we're excited about it. This summer, we're going to my family in [Location]. Having plans, projects, and social interactions is essential. Routine means no plans, staying in [City] without any excitement.

Speaker 1 [01:05:07]: What could make you leave your partner?

Speaker 2 [01:05:13]: If he falls in love with someone else. Not just cheating, because I believe in forgiveness. But if he develops feelings for someone else, I'd feel threatened and it would end. Even if he just sees another girl without telling me, I'd feel threatened. We have to trust each other and discuss things openly.

Speaker 1 [01:06:22]: So it's about trust, as you said, "if he doesn't tell me."

Speaker 2 [01:06:27]: Yes. If he starts seeing another girl and hides it, I'd feel threatened. But if he talks to me about it, I could understand. It's human to have desires, and it doesn't mean he doesn't love me. But developing feelings for someone else would make me feel insecure and lose my spontaneity and confidence, affecting the relationship's balance.

Speaker 1 [01:09:24]: You said, "without fear of my reaction," it's important to share internal states without fear of judgment.

Speaker 2 [01:11:01]: Oh, definitely. I was still in love with my ex when we started dating, so yes. For the first six months of my relationship with [partner], I was still very much in love with my ex. I didn't tell him because I knew he wouldn't understand. It was my problem to deal with. I knew that with time, my love for [partner] would grow and my feelings for my ex would fade. But it was hard to move on. That's one reason I didn't want a serious relationship. I told [partner] from the start that I was still in love with my ex. He knew, but he never brought it up again. He never asked, "Do you still love your ex?" or "Have you forgotten about your ex?" or "Are you happy in our relationship?" He never asked because [partner] doesn't ask such questions. For at least six months, I loved him while still being in love with my ex. It was tough to fully move on and be 100% in love with [partner].

Speaker 1 [01:12:09]: You said he never asks such questions. Do you think it's because he doesn't think about these things?

Speaker 2 [01:12:13]: Yes, it's always a matter of interest. He just doesn't pick up on these things. It's like the client meeting—he won't remember. I'm sure he remembers that I told him on our first date that I was still in love with my ex, but he won't bring it up. He thinks it's something I need to resolve on my own, that it doesn't concern him. Maybe it's for the best because it would have affected him, knowing I was still in love with my ex [6-10] months later. If he had asked, I don't know if I could have told him, "Yes, I still love him." I don't know if he can understand loving multiple people at the same time. But I know I can. I feel 100% in my relationship with [partner] now, especially since I fully moved on from my ex. It took a long time for me to feel nothing for my ex. I didn't want to see him or go back to [City] because I was afraid it would reignite my feelings. I knew only time and distance would make my feelings for my ex fade and my feelings for [partner] grow. Time did its job.

Speaker 1 [01:13:35]: You mentioned feeling threatened earlier. Do you think [partner] could feel threatened by your love for your ex while you were with him?

Speaker 2 [01:13:48]: At the beginning of our relationship, definitely. I thought, "It's crazy that he doesn't ask questions, doesn't feel..." If I were with someone who still loved their ex, I'd be paranoid. But he never seemed to care. Maybe it's our different perspectives. He let me handle it myself, which was good because he couldn't have helped. Knowing my feelings for my ex were beyond my control, I didn't feel guilty. And [partner] never made me feel bad because he never brought it up. So it's good he didn't question it.

Speaker 1 [01:14:57]: Do you think he didn't feel insecure, or is it something else?

Speaker 2 [01:15:01]: No, I don't think [partner] ever feels insecure.

Speaker 1 [01:15:05]: Never insecure.

Speaker 2 [01:15:06]: I don't think he feels insecure in our relationship. He's not jealous or possessive, never feels threatened. But that's good because I have male friends—though I'm not as close to them now—but one of my best friends in [City], for instance, my ex would have had a fit if I saw him alone. He couldn't understand male-female friendships. [Partner] is cool with it, saying, "Have a good time with [friend]." We trust each other. Sometimes I tease him, "Aren't you jealous?" But he never is. I'm a bit more prone to jealousy.

Speaker 1 [01:16:00]: Yes?

Speaker 2 [01:16:01]: Yeah, I think so. Not that I feel threatened, but when he has a new female colleague, I'll ask if she's pretty. He doesn't care. It's good he trusts himself and our relationship enough not to feel threatened.

Speaker 1 [01:16:25]: You said, "if he trusts himself and our relationship," do you think it's a matter of confidence?

Speaker 2 [01:16:32]: Well... I don't know. I said that without thinking. (laughs) I don't think I lack confidence in myself. I trust him. But I love our relationship so much that I think it's human to have a little fear. It's not necessarily about lacking self-confidence. [Partner] doesn't question things because he has full confidence in our relationship and himself. I also have full confidence in our relationship, but I can't help but worry that he spends his days with someone who might be prettier, more interesting, funnier, and cooler. I think I'd be a little jealous, but I don't think he would be in the same situation. Maybe it's confidence... I don't know.

Speaker 1 [01:17:32]: You don't know.

Speaker 2 [01:17:37]: No, I don't know. I don't feel I lack confidence, but I just think there are girls everywhere who could appeal to him. Yes, he chose me, we're happy together, but I'm not immune to him finding someone else attractive. I think it's human. I wouldn't blame him. It's an animal instinct to feel threatened by someone who could disrupt the relationship. It's not jealousy, just that I value our relationship and don't want any shadows.

Speaker 1 [01:18:19]: Could it be related to your belief that you can love multiple people and your comfort with open relationships?

Speaker 2 [01:18:30]: Yes, maybe. Maybe [partner] doesn't question it because he's very one-person oriented. From my experience, I know you can love multiple people, but I know he's not like that. So I don't know why I worry. In his place, I'd be concerned if I had male colleagues. (laughs) But no man could threaten my relationship with [partner] because I love him too much. It would be impossible to replicate what I have with him with someone else. I wouldn't even want to. But I think I'll always be a little jealous when the occasion arises. (laughs)

Speaker 1 [01:19:27]: You mentioned that loving multiple people would be a problem if he developed feelings for someone else. You'd feel threatened and not be yourself.

Speaker 2 [01:19:41]: Yes, because I know [partner] isn't like that. I don't want a three-person relationship. I don't want to share him. If he has serious feelings for someone else, I know he's exclusive. I don't want to share. It would be the end if he loved her more than me. I was in love with him and my ex, but he checked all the boxes. Over time, my feelings for [partner] grew, and my feelings for my ex faded naturally. But if he meets someone who checks all the boxes and he likes her more, he'd leave me for her because he's like that, and I don't want to share.

Speaker 1 [01:20:37]: You mentioned—sorry?

Speaker 2 [01:20:39]: No, it's okay, I finished.

Speaker 1 [01:20:41]: You said the relationship was fulfilling for you. Do you also think it's good for you?

Speaker 2 [01:20:56]: Yes. Because we bring out each other's best qualities and mitigate each other's flaws. He's sociable, has many friends, likes to do things. When I want to travel, he's like,

"OK, let's go." He makes my desires his own. Whenever something matters to me, he ensures it happens. (laughs) I can't remember what we were saying.

Speaker 1 [01:21:28]: We were talking about whether the relationship is good for you. For example, does it help you regulate your daily life and achieve your goals?

Speaker 2 [01:21:42]: Yes. Because we share the same interests. He always wanted to travel but never found the courage to go alone. When I went to [Continent] alone for [1-5] months, he was amazed. We started traveling together, and he realized it was great. He had always wanted to go to certain places but never thought he would. With me, he does it because we share the same desires. He's not one to backpack in [Country] on a whim, but I am. I'm geographically independent because of my job. I don't want to be away from him for [1-5] weeks now, but we share these desires. When I want to go somewhere, we plan it together.

Speaker 1 [01:22:50]: Earlier, you mentioned that relationships help regulate daily life. Do you feel this way about your relationship, that it helps regulate your functioning?

Speaker 2 [01:23:16]: Yes, maybe. I'm more stable and settled. Partly due to age, I have a job, a business, and bills to pay. I'm more stable now. I don't think he regulates my emotions, but we get along well and don't drive each other crazy daily like in some conflicted relationships. Our personalities are compatible, and we regulate each other. We accept that we won't always understand each other and move on. If we clash, we eventually accept our differences and move on. Maybe that's how we regulate each other. I don't know.

Speaker 1 [01:24:30]: Do you think you're the same person as before your relationship?

Speaker 2 [01:24:37]: Not quite. I'm less selfish, as I mentioned. I think more about us and less about my personal desires. It's strange to say, but [partner] and I feel like one. When I'm away from him for a long time, visiting family in [Country], I feel incomplete. I'm less selfish, more about us than me.

Speaker 1 [01:25:09]: Do you think your relationship with [partner] has changed him as well? Is he different from before?

Speaker 2 [01:25:17]: Yes, he's more mature. I remember at the beginning, there were things about him that seemed immature. Now, he's more mature and thoughtful. He used to be careless about what he said in public. The last example was at a family dinner when he mentioned I wanted an open relationship at the start. I was furious. But he apologized immediately. He's grown up a lot since we first met.

Speaker 1 [01:26:01]: You mentioned immature things.

Speaker 2 [01:26:06]: In his thoughts. Sometimes, he has trouble filtering what he should or shouldn't say in public. The most recent example was when we were at a family dinner, and he brought up the fact that I wanted an open relationship at the beginning. [partner]! Afterward, I was furious. I said, "But [partner]! Do you realize you just said that in front of my grandparents?"

I said, "I understand that you feel comfortable with my family, that they are very open, we talk freely, we get along well, and that's great, and I'm glad you feel at ease. But you can't say stuff like that in front of my grandparents. Do you realize the generation gap? My parents can't understand. Can you imagine what they'll think of their granddaughter if you say something like that in front of them?" He apologized and said, "You're right, I don't know why I said that." It's things like that. At the beginning of our relationship, I thought, "He's immature, he says things without thinking," and I wondered, "Is he dumb or what?" But it happens much less often now. The last incident was really surprising; I thought, "Why did he say that in front of my grandparents?" I thought they would believe their granddaughter wanted to cheat on her boyfriend. It's a generational issue—they can't understand, and for me, it's obvious you don't talk about that in front of them. But he doesn't see the problem. On such matters, he's matured a bit, but he still makes occasional mistakes in his behavior.

Speaker 1 [01:27:31]: So what you describe as immaturity is his inability to filter and understand the interaction at the moment.

Speaker 2 [01:27:40]: Yes, and never putting the other person in a difficult situation. He made me uncomfortable and embarrassed me in front of my family, even though it takes a lot to make us uncomfortable because we talk about many things openly. We can even joke about sex in front of my grandparents without feeling awkward. But this time, I thought, "Is he mocking me?" Why did he say that in front of everyone? The fact that he embarrassed me in front of people I care about and whose opinions matter to me felt like a mini betrayal. He's betraying my trust on things that concern just us. I trust him, we talk freely, but it's not for him to share everything with everyone. It's obvious to me that this is something that concerns only our couple, and we don't discuss it with others. He has trouble filtering these things and understanding that if he says certain things, it will make me feel bad. I see it as mini betrayals. Especially at such moments, I think, "Is he dumb or what?" (laughs) I told him, "How can you not realize that it shouldn't be said?" But he does it less now. At the beginning of our relationship, he would often make me uncomfortable, say things, or make bad jokes in front of my friends. He doesn't do that anymore. There was just this recent mistake that I didn't understand. But otherwise, it's very rare.

Speaker 1 [01:29:50]: It's a kind of social inadequacy.

Speaker 2 [01:29:53]: Yes, exactly. And he used to say, "Why do you care so much about what others think? We don't care." But no, we don't care about what random people think, but we do care about what my parents, my friends, and my grandparents think. We can argue as much as we want and let the neighbors hear; I don't care. But not in front of my family. To me, it's obvious. He has a more global view, thinking we shouldn't care about what people think. It's a social and educational difference we had. At the beginning, I feared this difference would damage our relationship and make it not work because he hadn't studied much. He was very clumsy about these things, and I thought we didn't have the same social codes. But it turns out [partner] is brilliant and capable of studying, but his family didn't push him to do so. Now, he is advancing in his job, doing very well, and I'm very proud of him. Socially, we are now much

more in sync. He no longer makes me uncomfortable, and I don't fear what he might say in front of my friends. It's strange because I love him, I love my friends, my friends love me, and I know they won't judge. But I used to feel the need to control him, which I no longer feel. It was, as you said, just a social difference at the beginning of our relationship. But over time, we quickly adapted. I think I changed him a bit in that regard. It's good for him because even his best friend recently said he was more settled since being with me, more mature.

Speaker 1 [01:31:58]: Would you say you were afraid of being ashamed of him?

Speaker 2 [01:32:05]: Afraid of him?

Speaker 1 [01:32:06]: Afraid of being ashamed of him.

Speaker 2 [01:32:08]: Yes, yes. At the beginning, yes.

Speaker 1 [01:32:14]: Is that why you felt the need to control him?

Speaker 2 [01:32:19]: Yes, but today, I think he better anticipates what he can say or do in front of my friends or family. There was just that recent slip where I didn't understand what was going on in his head. But he apologized immediately and understood. Before, if I told him not to say something in front of my friends, he wouldn't understand. He would say, "What's the problem?" At the very beginning of our relationship, I remember thinking, "Wow... This might not work." But now, I don't think that anymore because now—well, he immediately apologized for the recent mistake, saying, "You're right, I was stupid. I'm sorry for saying that in front of your family. I didn't realize you were uncomfortable." Okay, for me, it should be obvious, but okay. I accept that we are not coded the same way, and he has already evolved a lot in this area.

Speaker 1 [01:33:10]: You mentioned that there wasn't necessarily much discomfort in your family, that it was even possible to talk about sexuality. I'd like to talk a little about sexuality. We know it can be a more or less important dimension in relationships. Is it important for you?

Speaker 2 [01:33:26]: Yes, yes. Yes, but it doesn't take on huge proportions. But... Yes, it needs to be... For me, sex is also a connection and a way to physically express our love. So if we're not in sync at that moment, for me, we're not in sync at all. (laughs)

Speaker 1 [01:33:56]: It's something important to you.

Speaker 2 [01:33:58]: Yes, it's important to me. Yes, yes, I couldn't be in a relationship with someone with whom I'm bored sexually or who has zero libido, who never wants me. I think it's also a matter of self-confidence. If a guy doesn't want me, it means he doesn't find me attractive. So he doesn't like me, so what is he doing with me? Maybe it's silly, maybe it's preconceived notions, but all the guys I've been with, I've never had this problem, and I think I would feel bad if they didn't want me. Now, if sexuality wasn't important to the person, there would be a problem.

Speaker 1 [01:34:35]: So you think, if I understand correctly, that it's somewhat a reflection of the relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:34:39]: Yes. Yes, I think so. I think it's important to desire each other.

Speaker 1 [01:34:47]: You've used the word "desire" several times. It's important to be desired and to desire your partner.

Speaker 2 [01:34:53]: Yes, definitely. But because it's linked to attraction for me. There's a direct link to attraction. If there's no desire, it's because you're not particularly attracted. It might be outdated to say this, but today, I know some people have no libido, and that's okay. Everyone manages their relationship as they want, but I know that even if I understand it, I would have a hard time dealing with it daily. If I felt I provoked zero desire in my boyfriend, I would feel worthless and unattractive. It's stronger than me. I know it's not necessarily rational, and many people live very well without sex. That's not my case.

Speaker 1 [01:35:33]: It's also a way to feel valued in the eyes of the other.

Speaker 2 [01:35:37]: Yes, also.

Speaker 1 [01:35:38]: To feel reassured.

Speaker 2 [01:35:41]: Yes, completely.

Speaker 1 [01:35:44]: Currently—roughly speaking—what's the frequency of your sexual relations? Over the past two weeks, for example.

Speaker 2 [01:35:52]: Yes, I would say three times a week.

Speaker 1 [01:35:56]: Are you satisfied with your sex life?

Speaker 2 [01:35:59]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:36:00]: Yes?

Speaker 2 [01:36:03]: Yes, yes. What's great is that we have zero taboos about it. Even sexually, if we want something, we'll say it. If the other doesn't want to, "well, no, I don't want to." But we can talk about it freely, make efforts to please each other, and it's cool. We communicate about it, too. So it's nice.

Speaker 1 [01:36:29]: Earlier in the interview, you mentioned that at the beginning, you wanted to be in an open relationship because it was important for you to experience different things. Is

the sexual aspect of open relationships also important to you, having different partners to experience different things, or was it more emotional?

Speaker 2 [01:36:45]: Maybe that too. I can't explain why, but fidelity was a concept that eluded me initially. I think [partner]—well, there was one other before him—I've only had [1-5] boyfriends I didn't cheat on. [Redacted]. Because I know sex can be entirely independent of feelings, it was the case for me. I've slept with guys I had no feelings for, just physical attraction. For me, sex is very linked to physical attraction. When there's love, it's even better. I could sleep with another guy without feeling bad about [partner]—if he knows, of course. I could be in an open relationship; I know that. Although if he suddenly wanted an open relationship, I would find it very strange. I don't know how I would handle it, but I think I could have been happy if we had agreed on an open relationship from the start, talked about it, and knew who the other was seeing. As long as there's communication and nothing is hidden, I don't see the problem. For me, sex can be purely physical. But [partner] doesn't see it that way, [redacted]. For me, it's not necessarily the case. There can be nothing more, just that, and that's it.

Speaker 1 [01:38:43]: Just physical attraction.

Speaker 2 [01:38:45]: Yes. Just physical attraction and the desire to sleep together, then goodbye. And without feelings or wanting to see the person again.

Speaker 1 [01:38:57]: Earlier, you said, "I shouldn't think like that" or "we shouldn't think like that" when talking about having extramarital relationships.

Speaker 2 [01:39:13]: They were never long-lasting. For example, my ex-boyfriend came to visit me in [Country], and I had already slept with a [Nationality] guy. I didn't care at all. But that was also because I wasn't in love with him, and I didn't see a reason to deprive myself since I wasn't in love and knew he wasn't the man of my life. I thought, "I'm living a unique experience, I've met a cool guy, I want to sleep with him, why should I deprive myself, knowing the other person isn't worth it?" But it's horrible to think like that because, poor guy, I put him through hell.

Speaker 2 [01:39:59]: And I do feel a bit guilty about it. But once again, it was related to my selfishness at the time. I'm not like that anymore.

Speaker 1 [01:39:59]: You feel maybe more empathetic?

Speaker 2 [01:40:04]: Yeah. More empathetic. Less in the mindset of "what I do with my body is my business and not yours." No, as I said, I really feel that [partner] and I, it's not that we form a single person, but we form a couple. What I do with my body concerns him, whereas before I used to think, "well, as long as my ex-boyfriend doesn't know, he's not hurt, so everything is fine."

Speaker 1 [01:40:29]: I'll show you a scale. I'll share my screen, and I'd like you to respond to two items on this scale. So I'll share it now. Can you see the screen well?

Speaker 2 [01:40:46]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:40:47]: So, in general, my partner really listens to me. One is not true at all, and nine is completely true. Where would you place yourself?

Speaker 2 [01:40:55]: Very true.

Speaker 1 [01:40:59]: Very true, so a seven? Why a seven?

Speaker 2 [01:41:01]: Seven or eight... Because sometimes I feel like he really listens just to please me. He listens when it's very important, when it's important for our relationship, for example, but if it doesn't particularly interest him, I feel like he sometimes pretends to be interested and doesn't really listen. But if I need him to be an attentive ear on a topic that matters to me, he will be and really listen. So overall, it's very true. But I can't say completely true.

Speaker 1 [01:41:29]: You said seven or eight then?

Speaker 2 [01:41:33]: Seven.

Speaker 1 [01:41:34]: Seven. So why not six?

Speaker 2 [01:41:37]: Not six because six is quite low. And when there are things I reproach him for, as I mentioned earlier, he will think, "okay, I hurt her feelings or I wasn't up to the mark," he still takes my comments into account and tries to improve. So he does listen. Six out of nine is really not much. We are closer to seven or eight... Yeah, seven is good.

Speaker 1 [01:42:03]: So my partner generally listens to my needs.

Speaker 2 [01:42:08]: Yeah. Nine.

Speaker 1 [01:42:10]: You would put nine?

Speaker 2 [01:42:11]: Yeah, I think I would put nine.

Speaker 1 [01:42:14]: Why nine?

Speaker 2 [01:42:17]: Because he does everything to make me feel good. And when I want something, as I said, he makes my desires his own, and he respects my balance. And yes, when I say I don't want to do something, he accepts that I don't do it and vice versa. So yes, he listens to my needs. I've never felt constrained or thought, "He doesn't care about what I think or need." On the contrary, he does everything to make sure I have what I need. Yeah, nine.

Speaker 1 [01:42:57]: So how satisfied are you with the relationship? It ranges from completely dissatisfied, very dissatisfied, somewhat dissatisfied, uncertain/neutral, somewhat satisfied, very satisfied, and completely satisfied.

Speaker 2 [01:43:11]: It depends on how picky we are. I'm torn between very satisfied and completely satisfied because, as I said before, sometimes I wish we understood each other better. I find it hard to accept that we are not exactly on the same page sometimes. But I know he is like that. He knows I am like this, and we accept it. So, does the perfect relationship of being completely satisfied exist?... I don't know. But I would like him to be more interested, less clumsy sometimes. But overall, I think I'm completely satisfied with our relationship. There are areas for improvement, but I'm still completely satisfied.

Speaker 1 [01:43:56]: So you answered in a verbal form. I would like you to respond numerically. If zero is not satisfied at all and ten is completely satisfied, where would you place yourself?

Speaker 2 [01:44:08]: Damn, I want to say nine (laughs). Yeah, nine.

Speaker 1 [01:44:12]: Nine?

Speaker 2 [01:44:13]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:44:15]: Why nine?

Speaker 2 [01:44:17]: Because for me, it's important to have arguments because, otherwise, there has to be some spice in the relationship and things we disagree on. But there are times when I think arguments could be avoided if we understood each other better on certain things.

Speaker 1 [01:44:33]: Why not eight and why not ten?

Speaker 2 [01:44:37]: Well, not eight because I'm very happy in our relationship, and we are close to perfection for me. But I'm not completely satisfied because sometimes I feel misunderstood, or he doesn't show enough interest. I feel a bit of a lack. Sometimes I think, "I wish he remembered this or that and asked how it went, showed more interest." So I'm not... Yeah, I'm at nine.

Speaker 1 [01:45:05]: You mentioned that it's important to have some spice in the relationship, even having arguments.

Speaker 2 [01:45:13]: Yes. Because if there are no arguments, it means we don't tell each other everything. It means there are taboos. For example, with [ex-partner], we never argued, and I cheated on him twice (laughs). For me, the fact that we argue means we trust each other enough to share our disagreements and opinions on certain things that might clash. But we are not afraid to clash, and we do it anyway. For me, couples who never argue can't tell me they always agree on everything. If they don't argue, it's just because they are not able to say they disagree.

Speaker 1 [01:45:49]: I understand what you mean. So it would be a sign of a healthy relationship to have arguments. But you also said it could add some spice.

Speaker 2 [01:46:02]: Yeah, yes.

Speaker 1 [01:46:03]: Does it refer to that, or is it something else?

Speaker 2 [01:46:07]: Yes, adding spice. If everything is always good and always the same, it can be boring. I think it's important to argue about some things and not be afraid to clash. Yes, it remains important.

Speaker 1 [01:46:34]: It's to avoid boredom in the relationship, to have emotionally intense moments.

Speaker 2 [01:46:40]: Yes. I'm not saying that only arguments add spice to the relationship, but I think it is part of it, arguing and then reconciling.

Speaker 1 [01:46:49]: Reconciling too.

Speaker 2 [01:46:52]: Yes, or moving on (laughs).

Speaker 1 [01:46:54]: Or moving on.

Speaker 2 [01:46:54]: But it serves as reconciliation in our relationship with [partner]. It's the same thing.

Speaker 1 [01:47:00]: You say this because you think that having arguments strengthens the relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:47:07]: It can. It depends on the subject of the argument, but yes.

Speaker 1 [01:47:11]: All right. We're nearing the end of the interview. What I'll do is summarize what you told me, and feel free to interrupt if you have anything to add, clarify, or if I misunderstood anything. So, at the beginning, you told me that you met [partner] on a dating app. You were in [Country] for a while for work, on a detached mission, so you weren't necessarily looking for a serious, stable relationship but rather something casual because being alone is something you dislike. You met fairly quickly. It moved fast, I believe, since you mentioned that you met his father very quickly, and he also met your mother soon after.

Speaker 2 [01:48:07]: Yes, yes, my mother, yeah. My father took much longer.

Speaker 1 [01:48:11]: Ah. Anyway, a member of your family. And then you moved in together about [1-5] year and a half or [1-5] years later, if I'm not mistaken?

Speaker 2 [01:48:22]: Yes, [1-5] years later.

Speaker 1 [01:48:23]: [1-5] years later. The development was quite natural for you. You mentioned that this relationship compared to your friends' relationships felt more equal. Something that bothers you when— you didn't mention a particular friend, but her partner is very... not directive, as you used the term "bossy." Is it critical?

Speaker 2 [01:48:51]: Yes, I think it's critical.

Speaker 1 [01:48:54]: So, too critical. This was not the case in your relationship because you accept each other. You both accept each other fully. This is something you returned to several times during the interview. Compared to your previous relationships, you said you found this one healthier. It's healthier partly because you are in love and, as you mentioned later, the selfishness you had before is replaced with a sense of "us," which leads to more projection and acceptance.

Speaker 2 [01:49:33]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:49:36]: You said that a high-quality relationship for you is one where you flourish and can be yourself. Conversely, a low-quality relationship is one where you can't be yourself, where you diminish yourself. You talked a lot about this notion because if you are not comfortable in the relationship, then you are not comfortable with yourself. It's also important for you to love the other person and to love yourself in the interaction with the other.

Speaker 2 [01:50:08]: Yes, completely.

Speaker 1 [01:50:12]: You mentioned other things that are important to you in the relationship: trust, communication, among others. And you said that love is important to you in a relationship. You know your partner loves you because he tells you and because you feel it.

Speaker 2 [01:50:30]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:50:33]: You talked about the positive and negative interactions you've had. You said you had many positive interactions and that the negative interactions included an argument about a subject where you felt [partner] had difficulty understanding what you needed to hear. We later returned to this subject, where sometimes he has a problem, according to you, with filtering and understanding the interaction at the moment, particularly with your father, which bothered you. Sometimes, you understand that there are subjects where he might not be the best support because he won't provide the support you need or want. You talked about how you resolve conflicts by sleeping on it and moving on, letting time pass, letting things settle. As you said, you can be very emotional, and he can be very direct and bossy. So letting emotions settle and time pass helps you resolve conflicts.

Speaker 2 [01:51:49]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:51:50]: You said that you find this relationship good for you because it helps you regulate yourself, especially in reaching your own goals in general. You mentioned that what could potentially make you leave him is if he started having feelings for someone else. Once again, you would feel threatened, and your behavior would change, disrupting the comfort you have in this interaction. So if that changes, like a domino effect, everything would become unbalanced. You said you think this relationship has changed you, making you more empathetic and less selfish than before. You project more towards the other person than you might have before, at least not in the same way in your past relationships. You said you think he has also

changed, becoming more mature, especially on the issues we discussed earlier. You feel safe in your relationship because you can open up and be yourself without fear about your identity or thoughts, without fear of judgment or reprisal. And you know that if you need comfort or are in distress, he's someone you can turn to.

Speaker 2 [01:53:29]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:53:32]: And finally, we talked a bit about sexuality, and you said it's important to you, particularly the notion of desire, which also reflects what the relationship can be like.

Speaker 2 [01:53:40]: Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:53:42]: Is there anything you would like to correct or add?

Speaker 2 [01:53:46]: No, it seems very accurate to me.

Speaker 1 [01:53:48]: Yes.

Speaker 2 [01:53:49]: Yes, yes.

Speaker 1 [01:53:53]: So I'd like you to do two small things before we end the interview. I'd like you to fill out a questionnaire that takes about five to seven minutes. I'll turn off the camera and microphone, but I'll be here. If you have any questions, don't hesitate. I'll send it to you right now.

Speaker 2 [01:54:09]: Okay.

Speaker 1 [01:54:16]: Also, a couple. Recording of what we finished in the interview.

Speaker 2 [01:54:23]: Okay.